heard of Tata before the JLR acquisition, but after the meetings, ‘dealers loved Ratan’. They were left feeling that he is a man of ‘honour’, who does what he says. In contrast, Ford had not been able to manage Jaguar well; it had ‘lost its relevance … it had lost its identity’ under Ford, comments Gorin. ‘It was obvious that he [Ratan] would succeed where the giants have failed.’ For Ratan, it was a matter of ‘installing business processes’, achieving ‘inclusiveness and growth’, he echoes. It was different from the way Ford did things—‘dismantling’ was their style.

Within a fortnight of signing the deal with Ford, Ratan also met the US dealers’ community at the Tata-owned Pierre Hotel, New York. ‘Here is a guy who owned over 100 companies, many of them global companies’, who ‘flew halfway around the world to meet us’, says Weidinger. In contrast, where Bill Ford, the executive chairman of Ford Motor Company, was concerned, he says, ‘We did not even meet him once.’

He adds, ‘Ratan Tata’s personal touch made all the difference.’ It was an ‘amazing experience’, there was a sense of ‘ease’ and he was ‘engaging’. With apparent delight he adds that Ratan has the ‘unique ability to make you feel that you are the only person in the room’ when he talks to you. ‘When Jaguar was owned by Ford, we felt that we were just a cog in the machine and when Jaguar was purchased by [the] Tatas, we became the crown jewels. And that difference alone, gave us such confidence in the new direction and leadership of Tata,’ Weidinger adds.

Ratan, often dismissed as a shy individual, is more effective in his own way than the typical multinationals heads who are ‘hard-charging go-getters, fast-paced and a kind of removed, cold guys’, says Weidinger. ‘Ratan is not a typical multinational leader … he is a very special, unique individual with a completely different perspective,’ comments Gorin.

Kant recalls that Ratan heard out the dealers and realized the changes he had to quickly make. He did the US meetings for ‘three years in a row’. They were a resounding success, and the dealers became his ‘most vocal advocate’, Kant adds. Ratan also held a worldwide conference of JLR dealers in Birmingham. His Q&A sessions gave him the opportunity to take note of customer requirements. And this got reflected in the changes he made in subsequent years.

A Landmark Moment